an identity for quite some time now. We are just bringing it into cinema," she says. It means films from Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bangladesh, Bhutan and Afghanistan will be part of an extensive line-up that includes Palme d'Or winner *Anatomy of a Fall* (2023), Bradley Cooper's *Maestro* (2023) and new works by auteurs Aki Kaurismaki and Wim Wenders, to name a few. A few will compete with Indian films for the top prize—a cash award of Rs 25 lakh. Filmmaker Mira Nair will headline the jury. By promoting cinema from these countries that don't have film industries as robust as India's, DCunha hopes the festival will empower creators by connecting them with producers, technicians and line producers in a city that is at the heart of filmmaking in India. At least eight first-time filmmakers will be part of a programme that guides them on "how to produce their next film". A platform will also be given to South Asian filmmakers from the diaspora, some of whom are making films in languages of their new homes such as Basque. As many as 30 Indian languages will be showcased, including Garo, Santali and Konkani.

The festival's independent spirit is very much alive. As DCunha notes, the idea is to "increase the visibility of an independent film, which would otherwise find it hard to get a regular audience". It also reflects in the festival sidebar Recap, which provides directors whose films missed out on an on-ground festival in the last three years with a screening. But DCunha notes MAMI's repute for championing Indian and independent talent doesn't imply it wants "an artificial divide between independent and mainstream". "Great content can come in a very big film," she says. "At the festival, big or small, the love for cinema is the same." ■

Suhani Singh



IN THE SPOTLIGHT Stills from (left) I am Sirat and All India Rank

FESTIVAL

MOVIES IN THE MOUNTAINS

The 12th edition of the **Dharamshala International Film Festival** promises an impressive line-up and some key premieres

With 92 films from over 40 countries, the 12th edition of the Dharamshala International Film Festival (DIFF) has a packed programme. The on-ground edition (November 4-7) will be held at the Tibetan Children's Village in Upper Dharamshala, and feature four screens (up from last year's three). A digital edition will be available online (November 8 to 14) with a smaller line-up, featuring films for which DIFF has online screening permission.

The line-up is strong. While Varun Grover's debut feature, *All India Rank* (2023), is the Opening Night film, Devashish Makhija's *Joram* (2023) is the Closing Night film. The late cinematographer Navroze Contractor will be remembered with a screening of Deepa Dhanraj's *Something Like a War* (1991), a film he shot. A restored version of late Malayalam filmmaker Govindan Aravindan's *Kummatty* (1979) will also be screened. Besides, DIFF will host the world premiere of *Bottle Radha* (2023), produced by Tamil filmmaker Pa. Ranjith, who, along with Academy Award-winning producer Guneet Monga, will participate in discussions.

"This year, for the first time since we started the festival in 2012, we decided to step back from actively doing the programming ourselves," state Ritu Sarin and Tenzing Sonam, the festival directors. "We were very fortunate that Bina Paul, an old friend and the former artistic director of the International Film Festival of Kerala, was happy to come on board as the director of programming."

The programming also includes the documentary feature, *I Am Sirat* (2023). Directed by Deepa Mehta and Sirat Taneja, it profiles Sirat Taneja, a transgender woman in New Delhi, who is a woman in her professional career but must be a son to her widowed mother and fulfil her familial duties. "Sirat played a transgender guard in the Netflix drama *Leila* I had the pleasure of directing five years ago. I guess we formed a 'bond' during the shoot. I loved her optimism, her curiosity and desire to deal with what many of us would consider an impossible life," says Mehta, who sees her own role as more of a facilitator. The film was shot without a camera crew and on smartphones, with Sirat in charge of her own story. "I hope that through this film people who are caught between duty and self-determination would be inspired by Sirat," adds Mehta.

The 12th edition of DIFF **will feature 92 films** from over 40 countries

The founders of DIFF set out to "establish a world-class film festival that would expose local audiences to meaningful independent cinema". In this, they have certainly succeeded. It's heartening to see a festival devoted to independent films going strong even after a decade and continuing to serve as an influential showcase of some of the best independent cinema from India and around the world. ■

Amit Dixit